Track Guide & Participation Rules

OpenForge Hackathon | SWAYAMBHU 2026-27 | Department of Computer Science & Engineering, JNEC, MGM University

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1. Eligibility & Team Formation

1.1. Teams must consist of a **minimum of 1 and maximum of 4 members**.

1.2. Inter-disciplinary and inter-year teams are permitted — members do not need to be from the same branch or academic year or same college.

1.3. Each participant may be part of **only one team** for the entire event.

1.4. A team must select **one track** (Track 1: Open Weight AI & Open Source Tools, or Track 2: Play Lab) at the time of registration. Teams cannot switch tracks after Round 1 submission without prior written approval from the organizing committee.

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2. Registration & Fees

2.1. Registration fee is **₹200 per team**, payable at the time of registration - regardless of team size.

2.2. Registration fees are **non-refundable** under any circumstances, including voluntary withdrawal, failure to qualify in Round 1, or no-show on the Final Build Day.

2.4. Registration must be completed and fees paid before the Round 1 submission deadline: **12th October 2026, 11:59 PM**.

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3. Round 1 — Proposal Submission

3.1. Each team must submit a **project proposal PPT (based on the provided PPT Format)** between **3rd October and 11th October 2026, 11:59 PM**.

3.2. PPT Format:

- Slide - 1: Intro Slide (Team Name, Project Title, Track, Problem Statement ID, etc).
- Slide - 2: Proposed Solution (What are you trying to solve, features. USP, etc).
- Slide - 3: Technical Approach.
- Slide - 4: Feasibility, Viability
- Slide - 5: Impact & Benefits
- Slide - 6: Research & References.

3.3. Teams choosing Track 1 must specify the **open-weight/open-source model(s)** they intend to use in their proposal.

3.4. Submissions must be made through the official registration/submission channel communicated to participants.

3.5. Only one submission per team is allowed.

3.6. **Shortlist results will be announced on 13th October 2026.** The top 30 ~ 40 qualified teams across both tracks will be invited to the Final Build Day. The organizing committee's shortlisting decision is final and binding.

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4. Track-Specific Rules

Track 1: Open Weight AI & Open Source Tools

4.1. Key definitions:

- **Open source:** the project's source code is public and carries a license that allows others to use, modify, and share it. Common choices include MIT, Apache-2.0, and GPL-3.0. The OSI license list includes more options.
- **Open-weight model:** the trained model weights are available to download or run under the model provider's terms. Open-weight does not automatically mean that every part of a model is open source, so teams should name the model and link its license or terms in the README.
- **Small and large language models:** for this challenge, a small language model has 10 billion parameters or fewer, while a large language model has more than 10 billion parameters. Teams are not restricted to any specific model — any open-weight or open-source model is acceptable, including (but not limited to) models like Qwen, Llama, Gemma, Mistral, Phi, DeepSeek, and smaller 2–3B parameter models, as well as open-weight speech models (e.g., Whisper) and vision models. The only constraint is on **closed, proprietary AI APIs** (e.g., Gemini API, Anthropic/Claude API, OpenAI API) — these may not serve as the project's core AI component, per Section 4.5.

4.2. Open-source or open-weight AI must be an important, foundational part of the project — not a cosmetic addition.

4.3. The final project must be published in a public GitHub repository.

4.4. The README must clearly cite:

- The exact model(s) used, including parameter count.
- A link to the model provider's license/terms of use.

4.5. Use of closed/proprietary AI APIs (e.g., GPT-4, Claude, Gemini via paid API) as the core AI component is not permitted. Such APIs may only be used for incidental, non-core purposes (e.g., generating sample test data) and must be disclosed.

Track 2: Play Lab

- **10-hour development:** All core functionality must be developed during the hackathon.
- **One Problem Statement:** Each team must select and work on only one PlayLab problem statement.
- **Prototype Focus:** Projects need to be functional prototypes, not production-ready products.
- **Technology Freedom:** Teams may use any suitable tools, engines, frameworks, APIs, AI models, or hardware unless restricted by their selected problem statement.
- **Pre-existing Assets:** Open-source libraries, assets, templates, and frameworks are permitted, but major third-party resources must be disclosed.
- **AI Usage:** AI tools and services are permitted. Teams must disclose significant AI models, APIs, or AI-generated components used.
- **Core Requirement:** The selected problem statement's core technical requirement must be clearly demonstrated in the final prototype.
- **Submission:** Teams must submit the working prototype, source/project files, and brief technical documentation.
- **Demo:** Teams must be able to demonstrate their prototype and explain their concept and technical implementation to the jury.
- **Originality:** Plagiarism or use of another team's work is strictly prohibited.

PlayLab is prototype-focused, not polish-focused. The core idea, technical implementation, and functionality matter more than production-level visuals or completeness.

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5. Disqualification Criteria

A team may be disqualified at any stage for:

- Plagiarism or submission of pre-existing/unoriginal work
- Violating track-specific mandatory requirements (Sections 4.1–4.4, 4.5–4.8)
- Providing false information during registration or proposal submission

Disqualification decisions rest solely with the organizing committee and faculty coordinators.

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6. General

6.1. The organizing committee reserves the right to modify dates, timings, venue, or rules with reasonable prior notice to registered participants, due to unforeseen circumstances.

6.2. Any clarification regarding problem statements, rules, or eligibility must be raised with the student coordinators or faculty coordinators before the Round 1 deadline. Queries raised after shortlisting may not be entertained.

6.3. By registering for OpenForge Hackathon, all participants agree to abide by this Rules & Regulations document in full.
